serving patriarch of the Janata Dal (United), this election doubles as a referendum on two decades of his stewardship; for Rashtriya Janata Dal scion Tejashwi, it's a generational battle for validation—this duality applies as well to the larger wholes they are part of.

In a polity where assembly contests have long settled into a familiar bipolar face-off between the secular grand alliance of the RJD-Congress-Left and the saffron combine of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA)—with the JD(U) now here, now there and smaller partners drifting in and out of the two coalitions—Election 2025 is taking on the shape of a triangular fight. That third arc belongs to election strategist-turned-politician Prashant Kishor, whose Jan Suraaj movement is attempting to rewrite the electoral grammar of Bihar.

Retaining Bihar is essential for the BJP, both to strengthen its position at the Centre and as a stage for the party's next big battle—in West Bengal next year

The stakes are high for other reasons too. After Maharashtra, Bihar is the next big test for the BJP in the post-2024 landscape, as it seeks, territory by territory, to make amends for failing to win a majority on its own in the general election and being thrown into dependence on coalition partners such as Nitish and Andhra's Chandrababu Naidu. In Bihar itself, the NDA had won 30 out of 40 Lok Sabha seats, leading in as many as 176 assembly segments out of 243. Even 50 short of that in a local battle—122 being the majority mark—will hand the BJP a springboard for what it hopes will be a series of giant leaps. Think of it as a cornerstone of the BJP's national strategy. Bihar is not only a necessary endorsement in the northern heartland after the erosion it suffered in Uttar Pradesh in the general election. The party also sees it as a gateway to the east—with West Bengal following in 2026.

As Bihar prepares to vote in a two-phase election—on November 6 and 11, with the results on November 14—here is how the chief players in the contest stack up in this mother of all battles.

NDA: Continuity with Change

The BJP, the lead party of the NDA, has never governed Bihar on its own; its power here has historically flowed through allies, chiefly the JD(U) and its former avatars. Nitish's 20-year incumbency—marked by cycles of alliance-hopping, and now, health issues—make him both an asset and an albatross for the NDA. Yet the BJP cannot afford to jettison him for two reasons. In the larger frame, the JD(U) is a crucial coalition partner at the Centre. And, within Bihar, Nitish retains a substantial Extremely Backward Class (EBC) vote—36 per

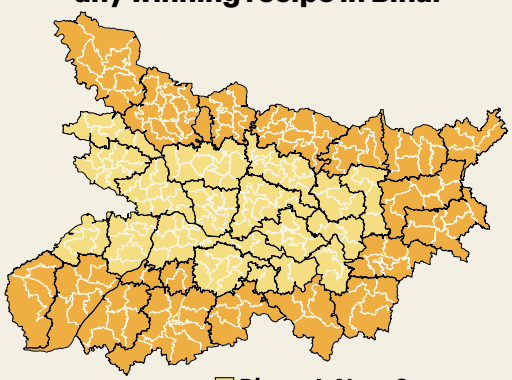


INCUMBENT DREAMS PM Modi, CM Nitish and deputy CM Samrat Choudhary in Gayaji, Aug. 22

PTI

THE STERLING STANDOUT

Aside from a Chirag Paswan-induced blip in 2020, Nitish and his JD(U) have proved why they are the must-have ingredient in any winning recipe in Bihar



Phase I: Nov. 6
Phase II: Nov. 11
Results: Nov. 14

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